Engaging communities in participatory sciences though the VERA platform

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VERA – the Virtual Ecosystem for Research Activation – is an online collaboratory designed to support participatory research in the social sciences and humanities (SSH). It acts as both a project incubator and a connector: researchers and societal actors can use VERA to find collaborators, manage citizen science projects, and access funding opportunities. Users can create projects directly on VERA, browse and join initiatives of interest and find collaborators. Unlike a simple project directory, VERA offers active collaboration tools and multilingual support, enabling work to take place directly on the platform. VERA was developed during the European project COESO (Collaborative Engagement on Societal Issues), completed in 2023, and is now integrated within OPERAS ' "Research for Society" service portfolio. (OPERAS is a European research infrastructure dedicated to open scholarly communication in SSH).

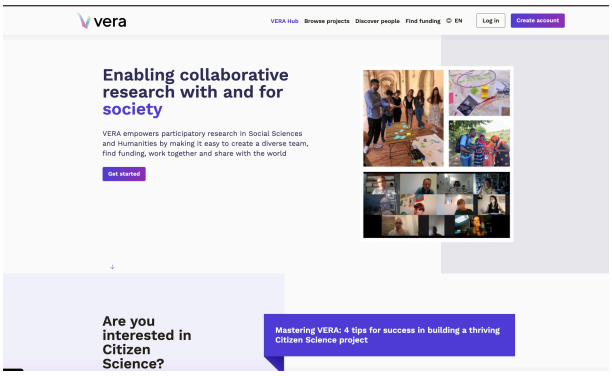

Figure 1 – VERA platform homepage

This poster explores how VERA addresses critical gaps in participatory research visibility and management. A key strength of VERA is **its participatory design** : researchers, citizen scientists, and stakeholders were involved from the outset, ensuring that the platform genuinely meets users' needs. This inclusive, iterative development approach not only improved functionality but also built a sense of community ownership, **reinforcing VERA's role as a practical tool for collaborative research** .

Another distinctive feature of VERA is **its commitment to multilingualism** . Recognizing the linguistic diversity of Europe, the platform enables users to create content in their native languages, while offering optional English translations for broader accessibility. By supporting multilingual textual data within a single project entity, VERA removes language barriers, promotes broader participation, and fosters knowledge exchange across cultures.

The commitment to multilingual engagement is not only a technical feature but a core part of VERA's mission to democratize research practices and lower entry barriers for non-native English speakers. It enhances:

- **Knowledge exchange** across linguistic communities, allowing research findings to resonate more widely.
- **Cultural inclusivity** , enriching SSH research with perspectives that may otherwise remain inaccessible.
- **Broader participation** , empowering local communities and citizen scientists who may not be fluent in English, making science accessible at the local level

By addressing the linguistic diversity inherent in European research contexts **, VERA positions itself as a platform that fosters equity and accessibility, making participatory research genuinely inclusive.**

VERA's ongoing development capitalizes on the **COESO project's lessons** . COESO supported ten citizen science pilots across Europe, covering fields like history, philosophy, political science, sociology, and anthropology, and engaging a wide range of participants, including artists, journalists, local authorities, and community members. Each pilot operated in the language(s) most appropriate for its context, reinforcing the importance of multilingual and culturally aware research practices. The pilots demonstrated the transformative power of small-scale, high-intensity collaborations, from problem formulation through to joint analysis.

Through these experiences, COESO and VERA have shown how participatory research can challenge traditional paradigms, stimulate innovation, and build bridges between knowledge

systems. **The lessons learned from COESO underline the potential of platforms like VERA to support community engagement, facilitate interdisciplinary collaboration, and expand the boundaries of SSH research practices.**

Today, VERA sets a new standard for participatory research in SSH. By prioritizing **user participation, multilingual support, and innovative technology** , VERA bridges gaps between researchers and communities, enabling impactful collaborations across Europe. With its sustainable framework and focus on inclusivity, VERA not only enhances participatory research practices but also strengthens the broader SSH research ecosystem, paving the way for a more connected and collaborative future.

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